

Yogi's Days Are Numbered If Blanchard Makes Grade

By FRANK ECK

(P) Newsfeatures Sports Editor

So you think the New York Yankees are deep in catching because they have Yogi Berra and Elston Howard? Wait until they bring up John Blanchard.

Where all major league clubs are content to have one strong catcher the Yankees have two — and another waiting in the wings.

Yogi, great receiver that he is, no longer hits for average and his prowess as a run producer has fallen off. At bat he is having his second poor season in a row. And his battered fingers might not take much more at 33.

Berra has caught about 1,500 American League games and has appeared in a record 54 World Series contest.

But Blanchard — even with Howard around — could be the Yankee backstop of the near future. He looks like the man who will eventually send Yogi into the bowling alley business on a full-time basis.

Right now the 25-year-old Blanchard is playing for Denver in the American Assn. Bill Dickey, the Yankee's Hall of Fame catcher, thinks Blanchard is putting in his final season in the minor leagues. Dickey is the former coach who tutored Berra and Howard and for the past three springs worked with Blanchard.

"Unless he's hurt, this will be Blanchard's last year in the minors," says scout Dickey. "I feel John is my boy because he was a good pupil. He's quite a catcher now." It was Dickey who converted Blanchard from an outfielder.

Blanchard last spring won the James P. Dawson Award as the outstanding rookie in the Yankee camp at St. Petersburg. While every writer seemed intent on plugging Deron Johnson, a young outfielder, Blanchard won the award on his hitting.

Blanchard, a native of Minneapolis, has been in the Yankee

chain since 1951 when he played for Kansas City and Binghamton. He also made a stop at Joplin, and in 1955 got in one game with the Yankees.

He enjoyed his best season in 1957 when he batted .310 for Denver, hit 18 homers and drove in 86 runs. This season he is hitting fourth for Andy Cohen's Denver Bears who are battling Charleston, W. Va., for the association pennant.

If Yankee manager Casey Stengel is interested, Blanchard also plays some first base. He did in the recent association All-Star game. In the World Series last fall, Stengel tried Howard at first after Bill Skowron was hurt. That didn't work so he used Harry Simpson's and his double play grounders as a hitter were costly to the Yankees.

Stengel will have no such trouble with Blanchard. At least that's the report.

Lake Charles Wins La. Title

SHREVEPORT, A(AP) — Lake Charles' softball team will join Bossier City as Louisiana representative in the 1958 regional tournament in Oklahoma City over the Labor Day weekend.

Charles Spell pitched Lake Charles to a 3-0 victory over Thibodaux in the championship game of the Louisiana Amateur Softball Assn. tournament last night.

Spell gave up only one hit in pitching his fourth straight shut-out of the tournament. He pitched a perfect game in the first round against Shreveport.

Bossier City, the 1957 state champion, did not have to compete in this year's meet to qualify for the regionals.

In other games yesterday, Thibodaux defeated Lafayette 6-2, Lafayette downed New Iberia 2-1 in 19 innings, Baton Rouge topped